

CASE STUDY: AI @ SCAD Year 2: AI literacy, design innovation and launchpads for student IP

Danyl Bartlett
Savannah College of Art and Design
Savannah, USA
dbartlett@scad.edu

Nye Warburton
Savannah College of Art and Design
Savannah, USA
nwarburt@scad.edu

Ray Crowell
Savannah College of Art and Design
Sandpoint, USA
rcrowell@scad.edu

Keywords

Arts Education, Design Thinking, Artificial Intelligence, Open Source, Machine Learning

ACM Reference Format:

Danyl Bartlett, Nye Warburton, and Ray Crowell. 2025. CASE STUDY: AI @ SCAD Year 2: AI literacy, design innovation and launchpads for student IP. In *Special Interest Group on Computer Graphics and Interactive Techniques Conference Educators Forum (SIGGRAPH Educators Forum '25)*, August 10–14, 2025, Vancouver, BC, Canada. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3721242.3734006>

1 Introduction

The “AI at SCAD” initiatives - conceived in 2023, with the first milestone in February 2024 at the inaugural SCAD AI summit, have had a profound impact in developing an open, inquisitive dialogue regarding the application of AI tools as they relate to arts education. In response to our most recent institutional research, titled “AI’s Influence on SCAD Disciplines”, the institution sought to develop a series of proactive practice-focused curriculum opportunities that went beyond research and creative expression. SCAD instead sought to develop learning opportunities through which students could commercialize and distribute unique AI driven tools and solutions. In this talk, we will explore how Savannah College of Art and Design launched a cross-disciplinary AI incubation program, enabling their students to design, prototype, and commercialize AI-driven creative tools. We will explore how the development of a series of distinct learning systems enables students to bridge the technical and artistic gaps that exist within AI literacy at the institution, whilst also utilizing industry partnerships to create meaningful startup and IP launch opportunities. This talk will discuss how the integration of innovation jams, design hackathons and short, iterative learning experiences alongside formal credit-bearing 10-week classes provided the framework for students to ideate, develop and launch viable AI-powered products, tools, and solutions. This talk will also discuss how the Academic Solutions Team and Steering Group for the project ensured that the opportunities for AI literacy and product development extended beyond those disciplines and majors with established, pre-existing skill sets like Games Design, Visual Effects, and Computer Animation. The outcomes of the project intentionally provide opportunities

for students studying in fields such as Interior Design, Industrial Design, Preservation Design and Art History to also engage with this new curriculum and aligned learning infrastructure.

Finally, we will explore how collaboration with external commercial partners is crucial to the success of this initiative- providing access to resources, expertise, and critical feedback at key milestones within both the strategic development of the wider project and for students engaged in the classes and shorter learning opportunities.

2 Cross-disciplinary development

The potential for the widespread success of any institution-level initiative to develop AI literacy skills beyond the use of accessible off-the-shelf commercial products was reliant on bringing in voices and perspectives from across a wide array of stakeholders within the institution. To achieve this the steering group for this project first created a series of isolated, target-driven multidisciplinary task forces whose purpose and the primary objective was to identify stakeholder needs across the various creative practice areas that exist within each of the schools at SCAD. This approach ensured that any outcomes developed would benefit students studying Interior Design or Art History with the same rigor and long-term benefit as it would any student studying a more immediately relevant subject such as Visual Effects, Game Design or 3D Animation. In this talk we will explore how the initiation of “Stakeholder Stream Investigations”, chaired by subject matter specialists from different programs, alongside our iterative hack sprints were used to design and develop a comprehensive curriculum offer with a specific focus on AI product development, incubation and distribution of student IP.

3 “BRIDGE AI” Class

Though it is closest in parameters and structure to existing curriculum at SCAD the development of the “BRIDGE AI” classes were one of the most substantial undertakings within this project. In this talk we will explore how the development of this new approach to a 10-week curriculum model required the academic leadership teams to completely rethink the institution’s understanding of best practices in teaching and learning. We will explore how through developing an iterative “product first” curriculum methodology SCAD was able to reflect on the successes of its current curriculum model, in turn having the opportunity to envision the future of design education beyond the parameters of AI literacy. In this talk we will also explore how within the development of the 10-week “BRIDGE AI” class SCAD academic leaders were required to reflect on the accessibility of knowledge for, and entry profile of, students

Permission to make digital or hard copies of all or part of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SIGGRAPH Educators Forum '25, Vancouver, BC, Canada

© 2025 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 979-8-4007-1544-0/2025/08

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3721242.3734006>

coming into the class and as a result develop more democratized approaches to what is arguably a steep learning curve.

4 Innovation Jams & Hacks

Taking direct influence from the hugely successful Global Game Jam model, in this talk we will explore how the team sought to utilize iterative innovation jams and hackathons as a method to develop comprehensive product focused learning experiences. With an emphasis placed on collaboration open exploration and the vital importance of open-source materials and resources, these jams and hacks were instrumental in allowing steering group to understand an alternative curriculum model that could be provided to students potentially accelerating their journey toward the creation and launch of successful AI tools. In this talk we will also discuss how the “jams and hacks” model became a part of the final curriculum offer under the “AI at SCAD” umbrella, creating accessible fast-paced learning moments for students at both undergraduate and graduate levels of study.

5 Product and IP Launchpad

A primary goal of this university-wide initiative was to create the infrastructure through which students were able to develop, produce and launch products and IP. In this talk we will explore the steps taken to identify the resources and build the systems needed to create the needed incubation model. This includes the process by which the SCAD Ventures and Academic Solutions teams worked collaboratively to stress test a series of potential launchpad platforms, and how academic leaders works collaboratively with stakeholders across the institution to develop the narrative needed to steer the student population in a new direction-creating and launching products that exist almost entirely in a digital space. In this talk we will also discuss leveraging open source and blockchain distribution models.

References

- Global Game Jam. (n.d.). Global Game Jam. Retrieved February 17, 2025, from <https://globalgamejam.org>
- Savannah College of Art and Design (SCAD). (2024). AI Insights 2024. Retrieved February 17, 2025, from <https://www.scad.edu/about/industry-partnerships/scadask/ai-insights-2024>